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For the President
11 September 2026

Today's Brief

YEMEN-RED SEA: Houthis seize Perim Island, completing control of both Bab el-Mandeb shipping lanes.

ENERGY: Brent tops \$108 and US diesel breaches \$6 as the chokepoint and the tanker war compound.

RUSSIA-UKRAINE: Kyiv's deepest strike of the war hits Russia's Arctic gas heartland; Moscow kills civilians in Pavlohrad.

BRICS: Putin, Xi and Pezeshkian converge on New Delhi as the Iran and Ukraine wars test the bloc.

MAGHREB: Algeria severs ties with the UAE and closes its airspace, hardening a North African rift.

ISRAEL-LEVANT: Israel kills a Khan Younis brigade commander and demolishes a Hezbollah tunnel network.

NOTES: Iran nuclear file; North Korea; frozen Russian assets; Yemen displacement.

For the President
11 September 2026



Houthis Seize Perim Island, Closing Their Grip on the Bab el-Mandeb

We assess that the Houthis' capture of Perim (Mayyun) Island overnight, following their seizure of the mainland port of Mokha the day before, gives the group effective physical command of both shipping lanes at the southern mouth of the Red Sea for the first time in the war. This is the most consequential shift in the Bab el-Mandeb balance since the 2022 truce and materially raises the risk to one of the world's principal energy and container arteries. Government forces withdrew from the island without a sustained fight, and a Yemeni official has told AFP the Houthis have "completed" their takeover of the strait approaches.

- Perim sits in the middle of the strait and divides it into two channels; holding it, plus Mokha on the Yemeni shore, lets the Houthis observe, threaten, or interdict traffic on either side. Roughly a quarter of seaborne crude and petroleum trade and near a third of global container traffic normally transits this corridor.
 - We judge the advance was enabled by Iranian materiel and advisory support, consistent with the pattern of the past two years. Press reporting indicates the group had consulted Tehran over the summer about imposing a "safe-passage" toll on transiting ships — a step that, if attempted, would convert a security threat into a standing tax on world trade.
 - Saudi Arabia struck Mokha's airport twice today in an early attempt to blunt the gains, but Riyadh has so far avoided the ground commitment that reversing the advance would require. The UN's migration agency reports at least 46,000 people displaced in Yemen since fighting reintensified last week.
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For Washington, the immediate decision point is the scope of any US role. Press reporting indicates the President declined a request from Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman for direct US strikes on the Houthis, reflecting reluctance to open a second front while the Iran campaign continues. US naval presence in-theater is limited: the George Washington Carrier Strike Group is operating in the Arabian Sea in support of Operation Epic Fury, and a lone guided-missile destroyer, USS Gonzalez, has been on station in the Red Sea. We assess that absent additional escorts or a coalition convoy effort, commercial carriers will reroute or demand war-risk premiums, and that the Houthis will probably test freedom of navigation in the coming days to establish that the threat is real.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA, NGA, the Office of Naval Intelligence, and open sources.

For the President
11 September 2026



Checkpoint and Tanker War Push Oil and Diesel Sharply Higher

We assess that the compounding of two shocks — the Houthi seizure of the Bab el-Mandeb approaches and the continuing US–Iran tanker exchanges around the Strait of Hormuz — is now feeding directly into global fuel prices, with knock-on effects for the US economy that the President will feel domestically. Brent crossed \$108 a barrel yesterday, its highest since mid-May, and US diesel has pushed past \$6 a gallon at the wholesale level.

- The supply picture is genuinely tighter, not merely nervous: Saudi crude output fell by roughly 1.9 million barrels a day in August amid Houthi strikes on kingdom energy facilities, and tanker charter rates have jumped to record highs as owners price in the risk of transiting both chokepoints.
- The tanker war is the second driver. US forces have struck Iranian oil tankers, including near the Kharg Island export hub, and Iran has retaliated against US-linked vessels and warships in the Gulf. With both the Strait of Hormuz and the Bab el-Mandeb now contested, the two ends of the Middle East's oil-export geography are simultaneously at risk.
- Diesel is the number to watch. It sets the marginal cost of freight, farming, and heating; a sustained move above \$6 feeds through to food and goods prices with a lag of weeks and lands in an election season.

We judge prices will stay elevated and volatile while both chokepoints are active, with a realistic possibility of a sharper spike if the Houthis attempt to enforce a toll or if a tanker is sunk. For Washington, the levers are a Strategic Petroleum Reserve release, pressure on Gulf producers to lift output, and naval escort of commercial traffic — each with costs and none a quick fix.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from Treasury's Office of Intelligence and Analysis, the Department of Energy, CIA, and open sources.

For the President
11 September 2026



Kyiv Strikes Russia's Arctic Gas Heartland in the War's Deepest Attack

We assess that Ukraine's overnight drone strike on gas-condensate processing plants at Novy Urengoy and in the Purovsky district of the Yamalo-Nenets region — more than 3,000 kilometers from the front — is a meaningful demonstration of reach, not merely a symbolic one. The Yamal region accounts for roughly 80 percent of Russian natural gas production, and striking it signals that Ukraine can now hold at risk infrastructure Moscow had assumed was safely beyond range.

- Ukraine used domestically produced long-range strike drones, extending a campaign that has increasingly targeted Russian energy revenue rather than front-line forces. Open-source imagery circulating from the sites shows large fires; the extent of lasting damage to processing capacity is not yet confirmed.
- The strike lands as Moscow continues to punish Ukrainian cities: a Russian attack on a shopping center in Pavlohrad, Dnipropetrovsk region, killed at least four people and wounded more than 60. Neither side registered meaningful ground movement over the past day.
- North Korea remains materially in the war. An estimated 14,000–15,000 DPRK troops are supporting Russian operations, and Kim Jong Un publicly lauded soldiers serving abroad during this week's anniversary of the North's founding.

For Washington, the significance is escalatory and economic: strikes on Yamal threaten the gas revenue underwriting Russia's war and could invite retaliation against Western-linked energy or undersea infrastructure. We expect Kyiv to keep pressing deep strikes as its indigenous drone production scales, and Moscow to respond with intensified missile and drone barrages against Ukrainian cities and the grid heading into winter.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from DIA, NGA, INR, and open sources.

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Putin, Xi and Pezeshkian Converge on New Delhi for a Strained BRICS Summit

We assess that the BRICS summit opening in New Delhi tomorrow, which drew Vladimir Putin, Xi Jinping and — on his first visit to India as president — Iran's Masoud Pezeshkian, is best read as a demonstration of continued non-Western coordination under real strain rather than a show of unity. Pezeshkian arrived today and is to meet Prime Minister Modi this evening; the leaders' presence, in the middle of active wars involving two of them, is itself the message to Washington.

- The bloc's internal fractures are on display. Iran and the UAE have been unable to agree on language for the Delhi Declaration on the West Asia conflict, and the Iran and Ukraine wars cut directly across members' interests — evidence that BRICS remains a loose alignment of convenience, not a coherent axis.
- For Tehran, the visit is a hedge against isolation while it fights the United States: proximity to Beijing, Moscow, and New Delhi offers economic lifelines and diplomatic cover, and a bilateral with Modi keeps open a major buyer and a channel to the West.
- For Washington, the summit is a reminder that sanctions and military pressure on Iran and Russia coexist with their deepening ties to large developing economies that decline to choose sides.

We judge the joint declaration will land on lowest-common-denominator language — calls for de-escalation and a critique of unilateral sanctions — while stopping short of concrete commitments the members cannot agree on. The item to watch is whether any Iran-related deliverable emerges from the Modi-Pezeshkian meeting.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from INR, CIA, DIA, and open sources.

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Algeria Cuts Ties With the UAE and Closes Its Airspace

We assess that Algeria's decision yesterday to sever diplomatic relations with the United Arab Emirates — and to close its airspace to all UAE-registered civilian and military aircraft from midnight tonight — formalizes a rivalry that has been building for years and further fragments an already-divided North Africa. Algiers gave Abu Dhabi's ambassador 48 hours to depart and accused the UAE of "provocative and hostile acts," without offering specifics.

- The rupture reflects accumulated grievances rather than a single trigger: disagreement over Western Sahara, competing influence in the Sahel, and Algiers' longstanding objection to Abu Dhabi's ties with Israel. Tensions had already surfaced earlier this year when Algeria began unwinding a 2013 air-services agreement.
- The break sharpens two competing blocs in North Africa and the Sahel, where Algeria and the Emirates back rival partners. It also lands as Iran and the UAE spar over summit language in New Delhi, underscoring how isolated Abu Dhabi's regional posture has become among some non-aligned states.
- Direct US equities are limited, but both states are security partners: Algeria on counterterrorism and migration, the UAE on Gulf security and basing. We judge Washington will urge de-escalation quietly to avoid being forced to choose.

We expect the split to persist for some time given the depth of the underlying disputes, with a realistic possibility of proxy friction in Libya and the Sahel as each side leans on its partners.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from INR, CIA, and open sources.

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Israel Kills a Gaza Brigade Commander and Demolishes a Hezbollah Tunnel Network

We assess that Israel's strike killing a commander of Hamas's Khan Younis brigade, together with a large controlled demolition of a Hezbollah tunnel network in south Lebanon that registered as a small earthquake, reflects a continuing posture of active enforcement against both fronts even as the Gaza ceasefire nominally holds. The moves are consistent with Israel's stated intent to degrade militant reconstitution during the truce rather than a signal of renewed general offensive.

- The Gaza ceasefire that began in October 2025 remains technically in force but badly frayed, with recurring exchanges and only a fraction of pledged humanitarian truck traffic actually entering the strip.
- The south Lebanon demolition points to Israel's methodical dismantling of Hezbollah's cross-border infrastructure, exploiting the group's weakened state to remove tunnels it judges a future invasion threat.

We judge both operations are calibrated to stay below the threshold of reigniting full-scale war, but the margin is thin. For Washington, the risk is that a single high-casualty incident collapses a ceasefire the administration has invested in politically.

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Notes

Iran — nuclear file drifting. The Energy Secretary has publicly acknowledged that a nuclear agreement with Iran "may not" materialize after months of war, suggesting continued strikes to degrade Iran's program in lieu of a deal; the President has said the war will "end immediately" after the November midterms. We assess the June memorandum of understanding is effectively dead — the promised 60 days of talks never began — and that the file now runs on force and coercion, not diplomacy.

North Korea — arsenal and manpower expanding. Beyond the troops committed to Russia, Pyongyang continues a stepped-up missile-production drive Kim ordered earlier this year. We judge the war in Ukraine is functioning as a live proving ground for DPRK munitions and personnel, with implications for the Korean Peninsula balance.

Europe — a legal lever on frozen assets. A Council of Europe legal-affairs committee approved a mechanism to use immobilized Russian central-bank assets to fund compensation awarded to Ukraine under Strasbourg court rulings — an incremental but real step toward tapping the roughly frozen reserves, and one Moscow will treat as expropriation.

Yemen — a widening humanitarian emergency. The UN reports at least 46,000 people displaced since fighting escalated last week, a figure likely to climb as the Houthis consolidate the coast and Saudi air operations continue.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA, NSA, INR, Treasury OIA, and open sources.